

The 53% return-intent figure masks a fragile majority: with 31% firmly against return and 66% undecided on timing, Ukraine has a narrow window to convert intent into actual return by accelerating housing, employment, and safety guarantees before diaspora integration in host countries becomes irreversible.

The 53% return-intent figure masks a fragile majority: with 31% firmly against return and 66% undecided on timing, Ukraine has a narrow window to convert intent into actual return by accelerating housing, employment, and safety guarantees before diaspora integration in host countries becomes irreversible.

RETURN

IOM: Diaspora Engagement and Return Support Takeaways from URC2026

IOM presented its Ukraine diaspora engagement framework at the Ukraine Recovery Conference 2026, highlighting protection, resettlement, and reintegration pathways. The session outlined practical mechanisms for activating diaspora skills and networks to support Ukraine's recovery, emphasizing the need for coordinated state and international partnerships to lower barriers to return.

3R: Directly anchors the Return pillar: IOM's operational framework is the primary international vehicle for converting diaspora intent into structured repatriation pipelines.

UKRAINE.IOM.INT

53% of Ukrainian Migrants in EU Intend to Return Home

A Gradus survey presented at URC2026 finds 53% of Ukrainian migrants in the EU intend to return, while 31% do not and 66% cannot specify a timeline. The data underscores both the opportunity and fragility of return intent, suggesting that without concrete pull factors—jobs, housing, security—the majority could shift toward permanent settlement abroad.

3R: Key quantitative benchmark for the Return pillar; the 66% timing-undecided cohort is the primary policy target for near-term return incentive programs.

LINKEDIN.COM / GRADUS

4.2 Million Returnees Present — But Recovery Risks Leaving Millions Behind

NRC/ReliefWeb reports 4.2 million returnees and 3.42 million IDPs in Ukraine as of May 2026 per IOM data, yet warns that recovery programming is failing to reach the most vulnerable. Without inclusive reintegration infrastructure, returnees and IDPs face housing insecurity, unemployment, and social exclusion, threatening the sustainability of return flows.

3R: Critical quality-of-return signal: volume of returnees is high, but without inclusive support the Return pillar risks becoming a hollow metric.

RELIEFWEB.INT / NRC

1.5–2 Million Young Ukrainians Abroad: Youth Diaspora at URC2026

Razom For Ukraine highlights that between 1.5 and 2 million young Ukrainians are currently living abroad due to the war, and mobilized 30 young leaders from EU, Switzerland, and the US to attend URC2026. Youth diaspora engagement is framed as both a return pipeline and a skills-transfer opportunity critical for long-term human capital recovery.

3R: Youth cohort is the highest-value return target: early engagement at URC2026 can seed structured return pathways before career roots deepen abroad.

FACEBOOK.COM / RAZOM FOR UKRAINE

RECRUIT

Budanov: Ukraine Will Need Foreign Specialists — 'No Other Option'

Kyiv Post reports that with only ~11,000 labor migrants currently in Ukraine as of 2026, senior officials including intelligence chief Budanov are openly acknowledging that Ukraine will require foreign specialists to fill critical skill gaps during reconstruction. This marks a strategic shift toward international talent recruitment as a bridge measure alongside diaspora return efforts.

3R: Flagship Recruit signal: top-level political acknowledgment of talent gap legitimizes aggressive international recruitment policy and creates demand signal for HR ecosystem actors.

KYIVPOST.COM

ILO Local Employment Partnerships: Demand-Driven Skills Alignment in Mykolaiv & Odesa

An ILO PDF report details Local Employment Partnerships (LEPs) in Mykolaiv and Odesa that align skilling, upskilling, and reskilling directly to employer demand. The demand-driven model addresses acute skills shortages in war-affected regions by connecting job seekers—including returnees and IDPs—with specific employer needs through social dialogue mechanisms.

3R: Operational Recruit mechanism: LEPs provide the local infrastructure to match available labor supply (returnees, IDPs) with reconstruction-driven skill demand.

ILO.ORG

ILO Local Employment Partnerships Strengthen Labour Market Recovery Nationwide

The ILO article describes how the Local Employment Partnership approach is being scaled across Ukrainian communities to create jobs, address skills shortages, and support inclusive labor market recovery. The framework integrates employers, local authorities, and training providers into coordinated workforce development ecosystems, directly addressing reconstruction-phase talent gaps.

3R: Systemic Recruit enabler: scalable LEP model provides the institutional backbone for workforce development at the community level across multiple regions.

ILO.ORG

RETAIN

From Inactivity to Productivity: Economic Impact of Integrating Inactive Women into the Workforce

VoxUkraine research demonstrates that providing retraining opportunities and employment to currently unemployed or economically inactive Ukrainians—particularly women—generates significant economic impact. The study quantifies GDP uplift from activating dormant domestic human capital, positioning workforce reactivation of internal populations as a critical complement to diaspora return.

3R: Core Retain signal: maximizing the productivity of people already in Ukraine reduces dependency on return flows and builds the economic attractiveness needed to retain those who have returned.

VOXUKRAINE.ORG

Ukraine PM at URC2026: 'We Fight, We Suffer, We Stay Resilient'

Ukraine's Prime Minister delivered a resilience message at URC2026 in Gdańsk, signaling institutional commitment to recovery and framing national endurance as a foundation for confidence-building. This political narrative is critical for Retain: skilled professionals are more likely to remain or return when they perceive stable, purposeful state leadership committed to reconstruction.

3R: Narrative Retain factor: strong political signaling of stability and purpose directly influences the stay/return calculus of skilled Ukrainians evaluating their options.

INSTAGRAM.COM / URC2026

Ukrainian Immigrant Population in the United States: Migration Policy Institute Profile

MPI's Jeanne Batalova profile notes that the Ukrainian immigrant population in the US grew significantly after Russia's 2022 invasion, representing a diaspora segment geographically distant from Ukraine's labor market. The US-based Ukrainian community constitutes a high-skill, high-income diaspora cohort whose re-engagement requires tailored transatlantic mechanisms distinct from EU-focused return programs.

3R: Global context for all 3R pillars: US diaspora data expands the return/recruit pipeline beyond Europe and highlights the need for geographically differentiated engagement strategies.

MIGRATIONPOLICY.ORG / MPI
